tigers. Three days later, the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) asked the Wildlife Crime Control Bureau (WCCB) to gather detailed intelligence on the matter. NTCA member secretary Gobind Sagar Bhardwaj led a team to Jaipur to assess reports on tigers spotted in direct sightings and on trap cameras, the usual methods—along with assessing pug marks—through which tiger numbers are estimated in India. Moving beyond the usual tiger conservation issues—habitat management, prey base, man-animal conflict, diseases and threat from poaching—Ranthambore's missing tigers bring into focus the nagging problem of unreliable tiger numbers. Though NTCA's tiger censuses every four years have greater credibility now due to camera use, experts feel it is the low quality of day-to-day monitoring by local officials of deaths, injuries, births and disappearances due to movements to other places, where the real problem lies.

"The best monitoring model is to make tigers breadwinners for the locals, who co-exist with tigers, know how to track them and can smell poachers and outsiders. They can be community rangers. Tadoba (tiger reserve in Maharashtra) has been doing it well," says Sunil Mehta, member of the governing council of the Maharashtra State Eco Tourism Development Board and former member of the Rajasthan State Wildlife Board.

## MOTIVES BEHIND NUMBERS

At times, forest officials make big claims, blurring numbers. In November 2023, they announced a 25 per cent increase in tiger population, including cubs, in Ranthambore, raising numbers to 88. The current, conservative estimate is around 66, excluding the missing 15 tigers. Whatever the truth, the alarm raised over the missing numbers appears justified, given how Rajasthan's wildlife department had made light of falling counts of pug marks in Sariska before calamity struck. "We must strengthen our monitoring to be able to account for a missing tiger early through constant analysis of quality data," says Arijit Banerjee, head of Forest Force, Rajasthan, which is responsible for protection of the state's wildlife. Banerjee suggests a few measures—a drill to utilise the app MSTriPES (to monitor tigers) to upload information, watching over the correct installation of camera traps and ensuring their memory cards are copied, formatted and reinserted, and the use of GPS-enabled advanced collars on tigers. Banerjee also recommends the involvement of NGOs like Tiger Watch to make up for a shortage of forest guards and better training for Rajasthan's rangers. There certainly is scope for improvement—cameras on 11 out of 12 watchtowers on the periphery of Ranthambore are out of order, leaving everyone in the dark about tiger movement in those areas.

The past few weeks have been trying for the department. On October 14, a radio collared tigress who was shifted to the new tiger sanctuary of Ramgarh

# WHY THE WORRY

**Tigers are being lost due to sheer callousness and carelessness**




- **Alarm bells rang in October, with news that 25 tigers had gone "missing"; on Nov. 6, news emerges that 10 are accounted for; probes ordered into the 15 missing tigers**
- **The disappearances highlight lax monitoring, and hence unreliable numbers. Most watchtower cameras are not working in Ranthambore's periphery**
- **Forest officials often inflate tiger numbers; last year, it was put at 88 in Ranthambore**
- **Some say this is done to help politicians take credit, justify transfer of tigers to other reserves**
- **Some experts say missing tigers are a result of deaths, injuries and the moving out of weaker adults**
- **There's no answer as to why the missing big cats weren't flagged earlier**

*Graphic by* TANMOY CHAKRABORTY



**"We must strengthen our monitoring to be able to account for a missing tiger early. Episodic efforts have to be replaced by constant analysis of good quality data"**

**ARIJIT BANERJEE**
Head, Forest Force,
Rajasthan government